CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

CABINET MAKER IN THE AI ERA

Kitchens are the most expensive room in the house, and the cabinets are the part everyone touches every day.

★ **TL;DR — Around $75K median for shop craftsmanship you can start learning in 1–6 months, no license required. The catch: dust, precision, and competing with factory boxes on price.** ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

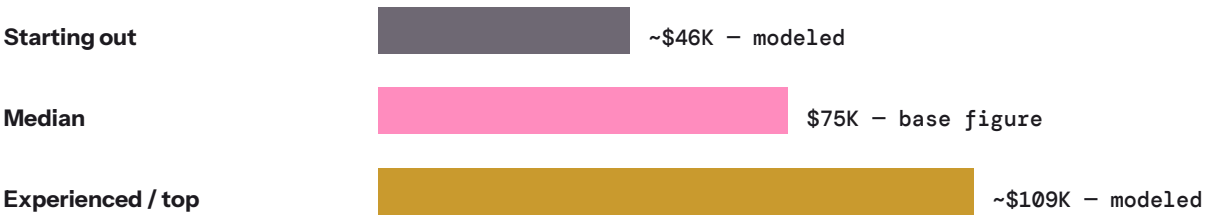
OUR TAKE: YES — WITH EYES OPEN

MEDIAN ~$75K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK LOW

- Why it works: remodels keep coming, and custom work — odd sizes, real wood, fitted storage — is what factories cannot ship.
- Where it bites: production shops run lean; the money follows custom and install skill.
- The AI angle: design software and CNC routers draft and cut — the fitting, finishing and problem-solving stay in human hands.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Cabinet Maker is a ~$75K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A CABINET MAKER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Read drawings and build cabinets, boxes, doors and drawers to spec

- ✓ Run saws, routers, sanders and increasingly CNC equipment
- ✓ Assemble, fit hardware, and finish with stain, paint or lacquer
- ✓ Install finished work level, plumb and scribed to crooked walls

Think: a furniture maker on a deadline — fine tolerances, production pace.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Cabinet design software generates cut lists and renders automatically. CNC machines cut standard parts faster and squarer than any hand in the shop.	Custom fitting is the human core: scribing to walls that are never straight, matching grain, fixing the mistake nobody budgeted for, and installs in real kitchens.

⚠ **Shop dust is a real health cost over years — extraction and a respirator are part of the craft, not an accessory.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ You make tangible things that last decades ✓ Workshop rhythm: focused, skilled, mostly indoors ✓ Finished kitchens are deeply satisfying to stand in	✗ Dust, noise and solvent smells ✗ Heavy sheet goods and repetitive sanding ✗ Factory cabinets set a price ceiling on basics

Good fit? You are patient, exact and quietly proud — the type who notices a door gap nobody else sees.
Bad fit? You hate repetition, fine dust, or measuring anything three times.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — CABINET SHOP HAND	DOOR B — WOODWORKING PROGRAM / MAKER SPACE
Shops hire hands for sanding, assembly and installs. You learn the machines and the standards in production, and good shops move reliable hands toward building and fitting. The standard apprenticeship of the trade.	A short woodworking program or serious maker-space time builds fundamentals — joinery, finishing, machine safety — before you apply. Slower to paid work, faster to competence once hired.

Smart move: Learn the CNC and the design software, not just the table saw. The maker who can program the router and still hand-fit a door is the last one a shop ever lays off.

Where you land after: Custom builder, lead installer, shop foreman, or your own small custom cabinet and built-ins shop.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
LEARN THE	GET INTO	BUILD BOXES	DOORS, DRAWERS,	INSTALL DAYS	ADD DESIGN

STEP 1 — Learn the sheet-goods world

FREE · WEEKS 1-2

- Plywood, MDF, solid stock, hardware and finishes — what goes where
- How a cabinet box is actually constructed, joint by joint

STEP 2 — Get into a shop

PAID · MONTH 1

- Apply as a shop hand: sanding, assembly, delivery help
- Machine safety from day one — this trade keeps count of fingers

STEP 3 — Build boxes to standard

ON THE JOB · MONTHS 1-3

- Cut, assemble and square boxes at production pace
- Learn the shop's standards for gaps, reveals and finish

STEP 4 — Doors, drawers, hardware

MONTHS 2-4

- Build and hang doors and drawers that close perfectly
- Fit hinges, slides and pulls fast and true

STEP 5 — Install days

MONTHS 3-6

- Scribe, level and anchor in real kitchens
- Install reveals every shortcut taken in the shop

STEP 6 — Add design and CNC

MONTH 6

- Learn the shop's design software and CNC workflow
- That pairing is the trade's promotion track

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- Today: learn how a cabinet is built and list cabinet shops within commuting range.
- Days 1–30: start as a shop hand; master sanding, assembly and safe machine habits.

□ Days 31–60: build boxes to the shop standard without rework.

□ Days 61–90: hang doors and drawers; join install crews on real kitchens.

□ Day 90: a producing shop hand — craftsmanship now compounds with every kitchen.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest "probably NOT you". → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ SQUARE, LEVEL, AND BUILT TO LAST. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.